The puzzling question 'How do we know something if it isn't there?' can be rephrased as, 'How can we know that something is absent?' Realists say that a true cognition must have real object (*prameya*). But the absence of something does not seem to be an object. Conversely, if it is an object, can it really be an absence? ***Kumarila*** held that an absence is a real entity (*vastu*) in that it is a real aspect of the perceptual situation. He says that an entity can be known as what it is and as what it is not, in accordance with its own features and the things from which it differs. So not being a cloth is a real aspect of a pot. This sort of non-being is a reality that is known not by perception but by another reliable means of knowledge called non-cognition (*anupalabdhi*). He says that this concept of absence and non-cognition help us to understand the real differences between objects.

Perception apprehends the positive aspects of a situation – what is there – but what is missing (for example, the pot's handle) is rightly apprehended by non-cognition (which must involve memory of something real that is the absentee or ***pratiyogin***)

The ***Prabhakara-Mimamsakas*** do not think that absences are realities and so don't need a ***pramana*** for them. Cognition of absence is just having a mental image of something potentially perceptible that is not presented to the senses.

Further reading: Hiriyanna 1993; Suryanarayana Sastri 1942

Anuvyavasaya: the ***Nyaya*** school holds that many psychological episodes pass unnoticed. That is to say, information may be received from the environment via the senses, processed by the mind (***manas***) and stored in the memory without being consciously registered. The elevation to explicit conscious awareness of an item of informational